

CHAPTER 3 — Back Seat

The engine came alive across the concrete deck.

Elias stopped with one hand still resting against the payment machine.

For half a second, the sound did not fit what he was seeing.

Then the hatchback rolled backwards out of the space.

“You have got to be kidding me.”

Zoe sat low behind the wheel, shoulders level with the top of it, both hands locked around the rim. The backpack remained strapped to her body. Her left leg stretched towards the clutch until her hip lifted from the seat.

She was not smiling.

She was not experimenting.

Her eyes were fixed on the downward ramp.

She was trying to leave.

Elias ran.

The parking attendant shouted something through the speaker. Elias did not hear the words.

The hatchback gathered walking speed, crossed the painted line and began turning towards the ramp. Zoe corrected too sharply. The front wheel struck a concrete ridge and bounced away.

Her foot came off the clutch.

The engine shuddered.

She forced it down again before the car stalled.

Someone had taught her enough to make the attempt dangerous.

Not enough to make it safe.

Elias reached the passenger side.

The window was open halfway. He caught the frame, pulled the handle and found the door unlocked.

Zoe saw him.

Her right hand left the wheel and moved towards the central lock.

Too late.

Elias opened the door and stepped onto the sill as the car continued rolling. His injured shoulder struck the roof. Pain flashed down his arm.

He reached across the centre console.

Zoe twisted away, one elbow rising to protect her face.

Elias did not touch her.

He seized the handbrake and pulled.

The rear wheels locked.

The hatchback stopped at an angle less than twenty feet from the ramp.

The engine stalled.

Silence replaced it so completely that Elias could hear the payment machine repeating its instructions behind him.

Zoe remained frozen behind the wheel.

Her left foot still pressed the clutch to the floor.

Her breath came through her nose in short, controlled pulls.

Elias kept one hand on the handbrake.

His shoulder burned where it had hit the roof.

"Take your foot off the pedal," he said.

She did not move.

"The car is stopped."

Her eyes remained on him.

"Foot off the clutch."

Slowly, she withdrew her leg.

The seat swallowed her lower body again.

Elias stepped down from the sill and backed away from the open door.

"Engine off."

"It is off."

"Keys."

"There aren't any."

The damaged panel hung below the steering column. Several wires had been separated from an old taped repair.

Elias looked at them.

Then at her.

"Out of the car."

Zoe's hand closed around the steering wheel.

"No."

The parking attendant had left the payment booth and was walking towards them in a fluorescent vest. A couple beside the lift had stopped loading suitcases into a trolley.

Elias lowered his voice.

"You nearly put the car down the ramp."

"I had it."

"No. You had ignition and momentum. Those are not the same thing."

The attendant called across the deck.

“Everything all right?”

Elias did not look away from Zoe.

“Family disagreement.”

Zoe’s face changed.

Only slightly.

Enough.

Elias corrected himself before the lie settled.

“She tried to move the car. No one is hurt.”

The attendant arrived beside the front wing.

He looked at Zoe behind the wheel, the open steering column and Elias standing outside the passenger door.

“You need security?”

Zoe’s attention moved immediately towards the lift.

Elias saw the route form in her mind.

Lift.

Stairs.

Pedestrian bridge.

Crowd.

“I can manage the car,” he said. “But give us a minute before you leave.”

The attendant studied him.

Then Zoe.

“Miss, are you all right?”

Zoe’s answer did not come.

The man waited.

This was the airport employee in the terminal again. A stranger asking the right question after the system had already accepted every wrong answer.

Zoe looked at Elias.

He stepped farther away from the door.

The choice became visible.

"Yes," she said. "I'm all right."

The attendant pointed at the damaged steering column.

"That wants sorting before you go anywhere."

"It has wanted sorting for six years," Elias said.

"That doesn't improve it."

"No."

The attendant looked towards the ramp.

"You're blocking traffic."

One vehicle waited thirty feet away, indicator blinking.

Elias nodded.

"We'll move."

The attendant returned towards the payment booth but did not go inside. He remained close enough to intervene.

Elias appreciated that.

Zoe did not.

She looked at the man, the lift and Elias in that order.

"Out," Elias said.

This time she released the wheel.

She climbed from the driver's seat slowly, placing one foot on the concrete before committing the rest of her weight. Her legs shook when she stood.

She disguised it by adjusting the backpack.

Elias noticed.

He closed neither door.

Open space mattered to her.

"You weren't stealing my car," he said.

Zoe said nothing.

"You were getting away from me."

Her eyes moved to the lift.

"Did you see someone?"

Nothing.

"Did the woman from the terminal tell you something after she saw me?"

Zoe's jaw tightened.

"Or did you decide Mac might have sent the wrong man?"

Her gaze returned to him.

Not at the name.

At the possibility.

Elias looked at the steering column.

The old plastic housing had been loose before she touched it. The wiring repair had been visible if someone knew what to look for. But knowledge did not appear because a child was frightened enough.

"Who showed you how to do that?"

"You said no questions."

"You said no questions."

"You agreed."

"I agreed not to interrogate you in Arrivals."

"This is still the airport."

"That is a creative interpretation."

Zoe folded her arms.

The movement did not hide the tremor in her hands.

Elias wanted to be angry.

The hatchback was old, unreliable and worth less than the parking charge suggested. It was also the one object he used every day and maintained well enough to remain independent.

She had nearly driven it into a concrete wall.

She had also been willing to gamble her body on a machine she could barely control rather than remain with him for another two minutes.

The second fact was larger.

Elias looked at the lift.

"Here are your options."

"I didn't ask."

"I know. You're getting them anyway."

Zoe watched him.

"I can take you back inside. We find airport police, child services or whoever is responsible for an unaccompanied passenger. You tell them you do not want to leave with me."

Her expression closed further.

"Or?"

"I drive you to the address Mac sent."

"That's not a choice."

"It is two choices."

"They both go through adults."

"You are thirteen."

"That doesn't make them safe."

"No."

The answer interrupted her.

Elias continued.

"I won't force you into the car. I also won't leave you alone on the fifth floor of an airport car park. So choose between the terminal and the journey."

"What will you tell Mac?"

"The truth."

"That I tried to steal your car?"

"That you refused the collection."

"I didn't refuse."

"You started the engine."

"That isn't the same."

"It communicates strongly."

The corner of her mouth moved.

Not amusement.

Recognition that the sentence had not been designed to frighten her.

"What happens if I go back inside?" she asked.

"Security asks questions."

"They already did."

"When?"

Zoe said nothing.

Elias watched the answer disappear behind her face.

"Who brought you through the airport?"

"No one."

"I saw her."

The denial had arrived too quickly.

Zoe looked towards the lift.

"Plain coat," Elias said. "Lanyard with nothing printed on it. Folder. She watched us meet and left without speaking to me."

Zoe's hands tightened around the backpack straps.

"She wasn't with me."

"No?"

"She walked beside me."

"That distinction sounds important."

"It is."

Elias waited.

Zoe gave him nothing else.

The attendant remained near the booth, pretending to inspect the machine.

A plane moved above them, low enough to make conversation impossible

for several seconds. Its shadow crossed the concrete, swallowed the hatchback and passed.

When the sound faded, Zoe said, "If I go back inside, they'll call the number in the folder."

"Whose number?"

She looked at him.

"No questions."

Elias accepted the boundary because she had answered more than she intended.

The airport would not return her to safety.

It would return her to paperwork.

He looked at the open car.

"You choose the journey, you sit in the back. You keep your door unlocked. You can ask to stop. You do not touch the controls again."

"And if I think you're taking me somewhere else?"

"You can see the destination on the navigation."

"You can change it."

"Yes."

"That isn't helpful."

"No. But it is true."

Zoe considered him.

"Keep the phone where I can see it."

"Fine."

"And don't call Mac."

"I may need to."

"Then stop first."

"Why?"

"So I can get out before you tell him where we are."

Elias studied her.

"That sounds less like a rule and more like a warning."

"It can be both."

The parking attendant looked at his watch.

Elias nodded towards the car.

"Terminal or back seat."

Zoe looked across the concrete towards the pedestrian bridge.

Families moved behind the glass.

Uniforms.

Cameras.

Doors that had already allowed every part of her journey.

Then she looked at the hatchback.

"Back seat."

"Not agreement," Elias said. "Understood."

Her eyes narrowed.

He added, "I know what a ceasefire looks like."

That nearly produced a reaction.

Nearly.

* * *

Elias disconnected the improvised ignition before moving the car. Zoe

stood near the rear door where she could watch his hands.

He did not repair the steering column. The damaged housing had existed for years; the wires had merely been exposed and separated. He reconnected the taped block, turned the engine over and listened to the idle.

Rough.

Normal.

The parking attendant walked closer.

"Starts?"

"Unfortunately."

"You paying for another twenty minutes?"

Elias looked at the machine.

The attendant took the ticket from him, flattened it against one palm and entered a code into the handheld device clipped to his belt.

The barrier receipt printed.

"No extra charge," he said. "On the condition that nobody else drives."

Zoe looked away.

Elias accepted the receipt.

"Reasonable."

The attendant lowered his voice.

"You sure she's all right?"

"No."

The answer surprised the man.

It surprised Zoe too.

Elias placed the receipt inside his wallet.

"But she chose the car over the terminal."

The attendant looked at Zoe.

She met his eyes this time.

"I chose."

He nodded slowly.

"Then keep your seat belt on."

He walked away.

Zoe climbed into the back seat.

Elias left her door open while he moved around the car. He sat behind the wheel, mounted the phone beside the dashboard and entered the destination address again.

The route appeared.

5 hr 46 min

Traffic extended the journey beyond six hours.

Elias looked at the estimate.

Six hours.

Wonderful.

He turned the phone slightly so Zoe could see it clearly from the rear seat.

"That is the address Mac sent."

She leaned forward without moving her body closer than necessary.

The map showed motorways, smaller roads and a final turn into a residential area far from the airport.

Her eyes remained on the destination longer than on the route.

She recognised it.

Elias said nothing.

He placed his hands on the wheel.

"Seat belt."

Zoe fastened it.

"Door handle works."

She tested it.

"Child lock remains off."

She looked at the lock pin.

"Phone stays there unless we stop."

"Yes."

"No calls while moving."

"Unless the vehicle is on fire."

"That is not funny."

"It was not intended to be."

Elias released the handbrake.

Zoe's eyes dropped to his hand.

The movement carried memory now.

He drove towards the ramp.

* * *

The hatchback descended five levels in slow circles.

At each turn, Zoe watched the opening towards the next floor. Elias used the mirrors to watch the levels behind them.

Neither mentioned the fact that they were doing the same thing for different reasons.

At the barrier, the receipt worked.

Elias joined the airport traffic.

Buses, taxis and private cars divided across lanes beneath too many signs. Drivers changed direction late, stopped where stopping was prohibited and treated indicators as optional declarations of weakness.

For ten minutes, the airport itself remained around them.

Hotels.

Rental depots.

Cargo entrances.

Aircraft crossing above the road.

Zoe tracked every turn against the navigation.

When Elias followed the blue line, she relaxed by increments too small to call trust.

When traffic forced him into another lane, her grip tightened until the map recalculated and restored the route.

He did not explain every deviation.

He kept the phone visible.

That was enough for the moment.

The city fell behind them.

Warehouses gave way to open road and a motorway bordered by exhausted grass. Four lanes stretched ahead beneath a pale afternoon sky.

Elias opened the front windows because the air conditioning had stopped working during a summer hot enough to make the mechanic laugh when he quoted the repair price.

Wind filled the car.

Road dust.

Tyre noise.

The faint scent of engine oil from the boot.

Zoe sat diagonally behind him with the backpack upright against her chest. She used the gap between the front seats to watch the road and checked the side mirror whenever a vehicle remained close.

For twenty minutes, neither spoke.

Elias was comfortable with silence.

Zoe appeared to be measuring it.

She shifted twice.

Adjusted one shoulder strap.

Looked towards the phone.

Checked the door handle again.

A dark saloon joined the motorway behind them.

It remained two vehicles back through the first junction.

Zoe noticed before Elias gave it conscious attention.

Her eyes moved from the rear window to the side mirror, then forward.

At the second junction, the saloon moved into their lane despite the road ahead being clear.

Elias watched it in the mirror.

Ordinary make.

Dark paint.

Two occupants, perhaps.

Number plate difficult to read at distance.

Not enough.

Zoe continued watching.

"Expecting someone?" Elias asked.

"You said no questions."

"You said no questions."

"You agreed."

"I agreed not to ask about your journey in Arrivals."

"You keep changing where Arrivals ends."

"It ended when you tried to take my car."

Zoe looked towards the side window.

The saloon disappeared behind a lorry.

She did not relax.

Elias marked that.

He passed the lorry without altering speed.

The saloon did not emerge immediately.

Traffic divided around them.

Maybe nothing.

Probably not.

The phone vibrated once against the mount.

A withheld number appeared.

No custom ringtone.

No name.

Elias allowed it to ring out.

Zoe watched the screen.

"You said no calls while moving," he said.

"I didn't ask."

"You were about to."

"I was looking."

"That is what I said."

Her eyes moved back to the road.

The withheld number called again.

Elias rejected it this time.

"Mac?" Zoe asked.

"You said no questions."

She gave him a flat look.

Elias almost smiled.

The phone remained silent after that.

* * *

The old car held heat despite the open windows.

Zoe's face had been pale at the airport. On the motorway, the colour reduced further until the shadows beneath her eyes looked bruised.

She swallowed twice.

Pressed her lips together.

Shifted the backpack lower against her stomach.

Elias watched through the mirror.

"How long since you ate?"

No answer.

Her stomach answered for her.

The sound was audible above the road.

Zoe looked towards the window.

Elias did not comment.

Five minutes passed.

She leaned forward between the seats.

"I feel sick."

Her voice had lost its edge.

Elias checked the mirror, indicated and moved towards the left lane.

The nearest emergency refuge sign showed half a mile.

"Can you wait thirty seconds?"

Zoe unfastened her seat belt.

"Keep it on."

"I'm going to be sick."

"Then use the floor."

She stared at him.

"Not because I prefer it. Because opening a door at motorway speed will kill you."

The emergency refuge appeared.

Elias crossed the solid line and braked.

The hatchback had not fully stopped when Zoe opened the door.

Elias seized the handbrake before she could move.

"Now."

She stumbled out.

The backpack came with her.

She reached the barrier, bent forward and retched.

Nothing came up.

Her body tried again.

A thin string of saliva struck the gravel.

Elias switched on the hazard lights and got out.

Lorries passed close enough to move the air around him.

He remained beside the car rather than approaching Zoe from behind.

She braced both hands against the barrier.

The attempt to vomit became coughing.

Elias opened the boot and removed a sealed bottle of water from the emergency pack. He placed it on the roof of the car where she could see it, then stepped back.

“Water.”

Zoe looked over her shoulder.

“Sealed,” he said.

She straightened slowly.

Her eyes were wet from retching, not crying.

The distinction mattered to her.

Elias behaved as though it did.

She collected the bottle, checked the cap and drank only enough to wet her mouth.

“When did you last eat?” he asked.

"I don't remember."

"On the plane?"

"No."

"Before it?"

"I said I don't remember."

Her voice rose on the final word.

A lorry passed, swallowing the sound.

Elias waited for the road noise to fade.

"I heard you."

"Then stop asking."

He looked at her hands.

Cold despite the warm air.

Trembling again.

Her pupils were slightly enlarged, but daylight and exhaustion could explain that. So could panic. So could something administered before the flight.

He did not ask.

Not yet.

"You're hungry," he said. "Possibly dehydrated. Possibly carsick. Possibly all three."

"I'm fine."

"You tried to steal a vehicle you couldn't reach the pedals in and nearly vomited without producing anything. Your definition needs work."

Zoe wiped her mouth.

"You don't have to be horrible."

"I'm not being horrible."

"You're listing things."

"I list when worried."

The word escaped before Elias could replace it.

Zoe looked at him.

He looked towards the traffic.

"Operational concern," he added.

"That sounds worse."

"It usually does."

She drank again.

Elias opened the passenger door and took the paper map from the side pocket. He placed it on the bonnet, weighted one corner with the travel mug and found the next service area.

Twelve miles.

"Next services," he said. "We eat."

"I'm not hungry."

"You are."

"I don't want food."

"That is different."

Zoe looked towards the road behind them.

The dark saloon did not pass.

At least not while they watched.

Elias noticed her searching.

"Did that car follow you before the airport?"

She tightened her grip on the bottle.

"No questions."

"Fine."

He folded the map.

"But we are not stopping at a quiet lay-by. We use the services. Cameras, staff, people."

"People don't help."

"Sometimes they complicate things."

"That isn't the same."

"No."

Elias put the map away.

Zoe looked at the open rear door.

"What if I don't get back in?"

"I call airport security and explain where you are."

"You said no calls while moving."

"We're stopped."

"That was my rule."

"It was."

"You'd break it."

"If you stand beside a motorway until something happens, yes."

Zoe studied him.

He did not threaten to call Mac.

He did not use the words police or social services.

Only the place she had already declined and the risk in front of them.

She climbed into the back seat.

The backpack remained against her body.

Elias waited until she fastened the belt before closing the door.

* * *

The hatchback returned to the motorway.

Zoe drank in small amounts and replaced the cap after each one. She held the bottle separately from the backpack, as though accepting water did not permit the rest of her possessions to become negotiable.

Elias maintained the speed limit.

The withheld number called a third time.

He rejected it.

"Why aren't you answering?" Zoe asked.

"No calls while moving."

"I said that."

"I agreed."

"That didn't stop you asking questions."

"Different category."

"You invent categories when convenient."

"It is one of my better qualities."

Zoe looked at the back of his head.

"What if it's Mac?"

"He can wait twelve miles."

"What if he doesn't?"

"Then he can practise disappointment."

The answer reached her before she could stop it.

A small sound.

Not quite a laugh.

More air than voice.

It vanished immediately.

Elias did not look in the mirror.

He allowed her to pretend it had not happened.

A sign appeared above the road.

SERVICES — 1 MILE

Zoe loosened one hand from the backpack strap.

Only one.

Only for a moment.

Elias saw it in the mirror and returned his attention to the road.

The service-area buildings appeared beyond the trees.

Fuel station.

Coach parking.

A tired row of food signs.

Ordinary people stopping because they were hungry, tired or needed a toilet.

Elias indicated towards the exit.

Behind them, several vehicles moved across the lanes.

The dark saloon appeared briefly between two lorries.

Then followed them onto the slip road.